

RAVI S SAHANI



MARKET WATCH:
Brands compete for the attention of consumer India

Talking Shop

Is the Indian consumer a local shopper or a global citizen? This audacious book maps the mindscape of the mall rat and more.



WE ARE LIKE THAT ONLY: UNDERSTANDING THE LOGIC OF CONSUMER INDIA
by RAMA BIJAPURKAR
Penguin
Price: Rs 495; Pages: 273

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

Defining the Indian consumer is as arduous and complex a task as defining Hinduism. By definition, definition is the act of defining or making clear, definite or distinct, a concept or a phenomenon. A stipulative definition freely assigns meaning to a completely new term, creating a usage that had never previously existed. Rama Bijapurkar's tome on the Indian consumer is more an ambitious attempt of

the latter kind. Talking about Hinduism or the Indian consumer, no one definition can cope with the plurality and the diversity, or be copious enough. Indeed, no definition really exists.

Yet, it is a definition everyone is looking for. It matters because India matters. You have to know the who, what, why, where, when and how of the Indian market because India is the fastest growing free-market democracy between Turkey and Tokyo. With a billion-plus populace, a trillion-dollar economy growing at 9 per cent and the youngest demographic profile in the world, knowing the Indian market is critical to growth. Those who didn't bother are still wondering what else they lost besides opportunity.

Should products be made for India? Or marketed uniquely in India? Is the Indian consumer a local product or a global citizen? Should transnationals localise or globalise? Why did Toyota's Innova work, how did LG and Samsung buy market shares, what did Nokia or MTV do to get it right? These are subjects of boardroom discussions. But nobody has quite attempted to landscape, rather mindscape, the Indian consumer. This book deserves to be read for the sheer audacity of its attempt at definition. And who better to attempt it than Bijapurkar. An IIM-Ahmedabad alumnus and now part of its visiting faculty, she has worked the numbers and the markets with the best minds at McKinsey and MARG, and boards ranging from Hindustan Lever to Infosys.

You may get thrown off by the jargon and the sheer spread, or the rapid pace at which questions pop up. Questions, warnings, lessons and suggestions fly fast and furious. Bijapurkar picks up the threads from 1991 and bombs you with numbers, reasons, perspectives and commandments. For instance, low-cost offering does not mean short-changing the consumer. Or, never mind the billions, we love the discounts. Be it the top of the rack or the bottom of the pyramid, there are instances and there is analysis. There is high-brow economics, pure marketing and pop psycho-sociology too. You may argue, wonder and disagree. For instance why is the book called 'We are like that only'. Shouldn't it be, 'We are like this only'? Or is the consumer changing? But then, this is quintessential Bijapurkar, whose normal conversations are 100-words-a-minute with at least three case studies and four perspectives. If you are selling or buying, this is worth the tag and the time. ■

NEW RELEASES



THE OXFORD INDIA GANDHI: ESSENTIAL WRITINGS
Edited by GOPALKRISHNA GANDHI
Oxford University Press
Price: Rs 850; Pages: 830

This compilation of letters, journal entries, speeches and articles is an attempt at putting together a posthumous autobiography of Gandhi without falling into the trap of clichés surrounding the Mahatma.



WHEN A TREE SHOOK DELHI: THE 1984 CARNAGE AND ITS AFTERMATH
by MANOJ MITTA AND H.S. PHOOLKA
Roli Books
Price: Rs 395; Pages: 221

Twenty-three years after the bloodbath that left 3,000 Sikhs dead, here is an analysis of the 1984 carnage in two parts, one a journalistic account and the other a story of an advocate's struggle for justice.



INDIA 20: CONVERSATIONS WITH CONTEMPORARY ARTISTS
by ANUPA MEHTA
Mapin Publishing
Price: NOT LISTED; Pages: 215

An effort at providing a better understanding of contemporary Indian art, the book, published in conjunction with a travelling exhibition by the same name, features 20 artists who have won international acclaim.